CHAPTER 3

BECOMING A LEADER?

REFLECT ON YOUR GOALS

Summary

This chapter emphasizes the importance of goal setting and goal striving for new leaders transitioning into leadership roles. It guides students to reflect on their leadership goals, develop actionable plans to achieve them, and build relationships with individuals who can support their leadership development. The chapter aims to offer practical insights and exercises that help students make sense of their new leader roles and effectively navigate their leadership development process.

Chapter Outline

Introduction

Opportunities and Challenges for Development in Your New Leadership Role

Goal Setting and Your Transition into Leadership

- Goal Exercise 1: Name your personal and/or shared goals as a leader
- Antecedents of Your Goal Setting

Striving for Your Goals

- Goal Exercise 2: Evaluating your leadership goals
- Goal Exercise 3: Identify people with whom you discuss important matters concerning your leadership goals
- Shared Goals
- Making Goals Congruent

Achieving Your Goals (or Not)

Conclusion

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the chapter, students should:

1. **Understand the Importance of Goal Setting:** Students will recognize the critical role that the goals developing leaders set for themselves play in their development as leaders. They can use "Goal Exercise 1: Name your personal and/or shared goals as a leader" from the chapter to articulate their goals. Exercise 2 further connects this understanding by evaluating the importance and attainability of these goals.
2. **Be Aware of Challenges in Goal Attainment:** Students will become aware that not all goals are easily attained. They will learn how important unfulfilled goals can lead to self-doubt, increased negative emotions such as anxiety, and a decrease in overall well-being, emphasizing the importance of goal adjustment when necessary.
3. **Engage Social Contacts in Goal Pursuits:** Students will understand the significance of social networks to achieve personal and shared leadership goals. Exercise 3 in the chapter guides students in identifying and engaging social contacts to support their leadership development.

Personal Development Activities

Activity 1: Think-Pair-Share on Goal Setting

Instructor: This activity is related to the book section "Goal Setting and Your Transition into Leadership" [see *Navigating Leadership*, pp. 41 ff.]

Objective: Help students explore how initial goal setting influences a leader's focus, time management, and overall leadership effectiveness.

Instructions:

1. **Reading Assignment:** Have the students read the brief case described at the beginning of the chapter that introduces Matt, a new leader stepping into his first leadership role.
2. **Think (Individual Reflection):** Ask students to reflect individually on the following questions:
    - Based on Matt's initial description, what goals would you set if you were in his position?
    - How do you think these goals would influence your attention, particularly regarding the progress of the goals, feedback from others, and the performance of your team?
    - How would these goals affect your time and effort allocation, including prioritization of tasks, time spent with different people, personal development activities, and personal life?
    - After considering these factors, would you change, adapt, or reframe your goals in any way?
3. **Pair (Small Group Discussion):** After individual reflection, have students pair up to discuss their thoughts and insights.
4. **Share (Group Discussion):** Bring the entire class together for a group discussion where pairs can share their key ideas and reflections. Highlight any common themes or differences in how students would approach goal setting and adjustment.

Activity 2: Group Analysis of Matt's Experience

*Instructor: This activity is related to the book section "*Striving for Your Goals*"* [see *Navigating Leadership*, pp. 45 ff.]

Objective: Encourage students to critically analyze the impact of leadership experiences on emotions, confidence, well-being, and self-views (e.g., leader identity), and to develop strategies for goal adjustment.

Instructions:

1. **Provide Context:** Explain that Matt has shared his experiences during the first trimester in his new role with a close friend. Each group will receive a different narrative that reflects his thoughts and feelings during this period.
2. **Group Work:** Divide the students into six groups and assign each group one of the following suggested comments (or adapt/create new ones):
    1. **Constant Change and Adaptation:**

        Instructor: Matt is proud of some early successes but is anxious about sustaining this momentum.

        "Our team has been in constant flux with new management styles, different work approaches, and ongoing changes in leadership. While we've managed to adapt and move forward together, and I'm proud of how we've handled the changes so far, I can't help but feel anxious about whether we can keep up this momentum. With even more changes on the horizon, I worry whether our ability to adapt will be stretched too thin."

    2. **Challenges in Scaling and Feedback:**

        Instructor: Matt feels disconnected from his team, noticing that they aren't as responsive to his leadership as he expected.

        "Starting my leadership role, I had to let go of an underperforming team member, a decision initiated by the previous leadership. This, combined with disagreements on critical project issues, was tough. Although the team has grown significantly and I receive positive feedback, I can't shake the feeling that there's a disconnect between us. They don't seem as responsive to my leadership as I expected, and with the team continuing to grow, I'm concerned about how I will manage the increasingly complex dynamics."

    3. **Rapid Team Expansion:**

        Instructor: Matt is feeling overwhelmed by the volume of work and struggling to maintain work-life balance.

        "When I first joined, I was managing a team of 10, but within three months, I had to integrate an additional team of 7. This rapid expansion was a significant

challenge, especially in terms of team cohesion and delivering results in record time. The workload has become overwhelming, and I'm struggling to maintain a balance between my professional responsibilities and my personal life. I'm still figuring out how to sustain this pace without burning out."

4. **Overcoming Uncertainty and Low Morale:**

   Instructor: Matt is confident in his technical skills but unsure about his ability to lead and inspire his team.

   "When I took over the team, we were dealing with extreme uncertainty and lack of clear direction, which had severely impacted morale and motivation. Through collaborative work with the new sub-manager and other area leaders, we managed to turn things around, and I'm confident in the technical aspects of our work. However, I'm still unsure whether I've truly inspired my team and whether my leadership is enough to keep them motivated, especially with rumors of potential organizational restructuring."

5. **Handling Pushback on Goals:**

   Instructor: Matt is receiving mixed feedback from his boss and team, leading to self-doubt and frustration.

   "I encountered several situations where the goals assigned to me were met with resistance by my reports. Although we eventually achieved the goals, the process left me with mixed feelings. My boss and team have given me conflicting feedback, which has led to growing self-doubt and frustration. Just as I was starting to feel more secure, a false accusation of mistreatment from a team member blindsided me. Although it was eventually dismissed, the experience has left me even more uncertain about my leadership abilities."

6. **Adapting to New Leadership Challenges:**

   Instructor: Matt feels unsupported by upper management and is beginning to question whether this role is the right fit for him.

   "I've had to navigate constant changes in team dynamics, with reports changing about twice a year. Since April, I've been leading a team that has grown from 10 to 18 members, which has doubled my workload. To make things more challenging, I'm still dealing with the lingering effects of a false accusation made against me. Even though it was proven baseless, I've felt little support from upper management throughout the ordeal. This has left me questioning whether this role is truly the right fit for me."

3. **Analysis:** Ask each group to analyze their assigned comment to identify the key elements mentioned (e.g., emotions, confidence, well-being, and self-evaluations).

Discuss how these elements might be impacting Matt's effectiveness as a leader, both positively and negatively.

4. **Goal Adjustment:** Have each group propose adjustments to Matt's goals that could help promote growth and development in the next trimester, taking into account the challenges described in their narrative.
5. **Share Findings:** Bring the class together and have each group present their analysis and suggested goal adjustments. Facilitate a discussion on the different approaches and insights, emphasizing how goal setting and adjustment can be critical to navigating leadership challenges.

Activity 3: Reflecting on the Social Aspect of Leadership Goals and Network Engagement

Instructor: This activity is related to Exercise 3 and section of the book that describes it [see *Navigating Leadership*, pp. 49 ff.]

Objective: Encourage students to reflect on the social dynamics involved in pursuing leadership goals and to consider how their network can support these goals.

Instructions:

1. **Initial Goal Exercise:**
    - Start by asking students to complete **Goal Exercise 3: "Identify people with whom you discuss important matters concerning your leadership goals."**
    - Have students list the individuals they currently engage with regarding their leadership goals, focusing particularly on those with whom they collaborate to achieve shared goals.
2. **Group Reflection and Discussion:**
    - After completing the exercise, lead a class discussion on the social aspects of leadership goals:

- **Leadership Goals:** What are some examples of personal goals or shared goals within their teams or organizations?
- **Network Support:** How do these identified individuals support the pursuit of goals? Are there any gaps in support that need to be addressed?
- **Collaboration Dynamics:** How do they collaborate with these individuals? Are these collaborations helping to achieve goals, or are there areas for improvement?

3. **Network Engagement Plan:**
    - Ask students to revisit their list from Goal Exercise 3 at the end of the class and reflect on the following questions:
        - **New Conversations:** Have you initiated new conversations with any of the people identified? With whom? How did these discussions contribute to pursuing your shared leadership goals?
        - **Impact of Discussions:** Were these discussions helpful in advancing your goals? If not, what might have been missing?
        - **Future Engagement:** If you haven't yet approached these individuals, could you plan how and when you would contact someone to discuss important matters related to your leadership goals? Consider how you could strengthen these relationships to better support collaborative goal pursuit.
        - **Ongoing Collaboration:** Plan regular check-ins or discussions with key individuals to maintain alignment and support in achieving goals.
4. **Sharing and Feedback:**

- Have students share their engagement plans with a partner or small group to get feedback and refine their strategies.

Outcome: By the end of this activity, students will have a better understanding of how to develop their network in the pursuit of leadership goals, a clear plan for enhancing these connections, and strategies to ensure ongoing collaboration and support.

Links to Other Chapters

Connection to Chapter 9: As you reflect on your goals, Chapter 9 provides an in-depth exploration of the concept of Thriving. This chapter tells you how thriving can motivate you to be proactive in your development as a leader and when you engage with your leader development and learning activities that in turn enhance your thriving further.

Key Reading

Benjamin, B. & O'Reilly, C. (2011). Becoming a leader: Early career challenges faced by MBA graduates. *Academy of Management Learning & Education, 10*, 452– 472.

Further Reading

Day, D., & Dragoni, L. (2015). Leadership development: An outcome- oriented review based on time and levels of analyses. *Annual Review of Organizational Psychology and Organizational Behavior, 2*, 133– 156.

Hammond, M. M., Clapp-Smith, R., & Palanski, M. (2017). Beyond (Just) the Workplace: A Theory of Leader Development Across Multiple Domains. *Academy of Management Review, 42*(3), 481–498. https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.2014.0431

Other Recommended Sources

[On the role of others and one's network as support for leaders]

Min: 3:00 / 12:29 - **How to Become a Better Leader with Adam Grant**

https://youtu.be/4PsQGm0d9rI?si=uoMv0LutbiiDhkGO&t=180

[On **goals** (content, setting and team)– Goals to achieve Momentum]

How do you measure success? | Q+A with Simon Sinek

https://youtu.be/nyqLJSclNb4?si=q34CCJH0Ndl2F-Mp